

A SHORT HISTORY OF FILM

THIRD EDITION

WHEELER WINSTON DIXON AND GWENDOLYN AUDREY FOSTER

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FOUR

THE HOLLYWOOD STUDIO SYSTEM IN THE 1930S AND 1940S

Sound films had been around since before the turn of the century when Alice Guy shot more than one hundred brief films using Gaumont's Chronophone system, which employed synchronized wax cylinders to record sound using a "Morning Glory" horn, a large acoustical "hearing aid," to capture the voices of the performers. But the Chronophone and similar processes prior to the de Forest sound-on-film process lacked the obvious benefits of electronic amplification, which de Forest's newly perfected vacuum tube made possible. Lee de Forest, in fact, was drawing on a series of experiments that dated back to the nineteenth-century work of the American inventor Joseph T. Tykociner, as well as work done by Eugene Lauste, who also conducted early experiments in sound-on-film. In addition, in 1919, three German scientists, Joseph Massole, Josef Engl, and Hans Vogt, created the Tri-Ergon system, which employed a primitive photographic sensor to transform sound into striations of light and dark, creating the prototype for de Forest's optical sound-track process.

THE COMING OF SOUND

To publicize his new invention, de Forest created roughly one thousand short films featuring comics, musicians, and vaudeville stars of the era. His invention, which he called Phonofilm, was a modest financial success, but without the backing of a major studio sound-on-film remained a novelty. From 1923 to 1927, the studios all resisted the coming of sound, realizing that it would create profound economic and technological changes. As with the advent of color film and later television, Hollywood was resistant to any changes in the status quo, and for all intents and purposes sound was suppressed by the industry until Warner Bros., in dire financial straits, risked

nearly everything they owned on *The Jazz Singer* in 1927. When that film clicked resoundingly with the public, a new era was born.

The major battle in the competing sound processes was between de Forest's sound-on-film and Vitaphone's sound-on-disc. Warners opted for sound-on-disc for *The Jazz Singer* and its subsequent talkies, and at first the other studios followed suit. But by 1930, sound-on-film was being used as well, and the need for a standardized system became apparent. Acting with rare unanimity, the studios voted for a sound-on-film process then being touted by Vitaphone, which was largely based on de Forest's work. Theaters, meanwhile, were still scrambling to make the changeover; by 1931, nearly all the nation's theaters were wired for sound. The motion picture industry would benefit from the new technology after the Wall Street crash of 1929 and the onset of the Great Depression, as audiences flocked to theaters to escape the real desperation of their own increasingly uncertain lives.

ESCAPISM

By 1930, ninety million Americans were going to the movies at least once a week, and many families, especially in the larger cities, virtually lived at the movies, watching the same film over and over again in second-run "grind" houses to avoid the cold or to escape the confines of their homes. In the wake of the Crash, many were homeless and jobless, and theaters provided an inexpensive and entertaining way to pass the time indoors. While first-run theaters charged top prices and ran a single feature a few times a day, neighborhood theaters would run two films as a double bill, along with cartoons, travelogues, newsreels, and coming attractions, to create a program running nearly four hours in length, repeated continuously from noon to midnight, or sometimes even twenty-four hours a day. For a populace deprived of the real American dream, the escapist fantasies of the Hollywood dream factory offered some relief from the drudgery of daily existence.

THE STUDIO SYSTEM

The studio system was in essence an assembly line that cranked out roughly a feature film per week for each of the major studios, regimented into "A" pictures, with top casts and directors and luxurious shooting schedules, and "B" pictures, which were shot in one or two weeks on existing sets, using sec-

ond-string players under contract to the studio for maximum economy. There were also short subjects, cartoons, serials, and even “C” pictures (mostly program westerns) shot on microscopic budgets in as little as two or three days from the barest of scripts. All studios maintained a roster of directors, writers, actors, and technicians under contract, to be used on any project at the whim of their bosses. Literary properties (novels, short stories, plays) for “A” and “B” pictures were purchased and then turned into shooting scripts. Cast, directors, and crew were assigned to shoot the films, while an army of decorators, costume designers, and prop men completed the sets. With shooting finished, the films would be edited into rough cuts and screened for studio executives, who would suggest revisions and retakes, while staff composers would create a suitable musical score. After sneak previews for selected audiences, the films would go out into general release across the country, often in the theaters owned by the studio, thus guaranteeing a regular market for their product. The films would sometimes be re-released later as either a second feature with a new “A” film or alone. The demand for product was intense, and the studios had to maintain a clockwork schedule to satisfy it.

Almost immediately, each major studio established a generic identity, which differentiated it from its competitors. Warner Bros. specialized in hard-boiled gangster films, social melodramas, and Busby Berkeley’s outrageously over-the-top musicals, while Universal rapidly became known as the home of the horror film, with such productions as Tod Browning’s *Dracula* (1931), with Bela Lugosi, James Whale’s *Frankenstein* (1931), with Boris Karloff, and many other such works. Paramount was home to the madcap antics of the Marx Brothers at their most anarchic, in addition to the sizzling double-entendres of reigning sex goddess Mae West and the droll misanthropy of comedian W. C. Fields. Paramount was also the studio that pushed the envelope of public morality with the greatest insistence, which, as we shall see, had major consequences for the entire industry. Columbia was considered a Poverty Row studio until Harry Cohn

Bela Lugosi as the bloodthirsty count in Tod Browning’s *Dracula* (1931).





Boris Karloff in the role that made him an instant star, the monster in James Whale's *Frankenstein* (1931).

lured director Frank Capra into his employ. Then, with Clark Gable on loan from MGM as “punishment” for refusing to toe the line for MGM boss Louis B. Mayer, Capra created *It Happened One Night* (1934), which swept the Academy Awards, made Gable a major star overnight, and put Columbia on the map.

MGM was widely considered the Tiffany of all the studios, making all-star vehicles such as Edmund Goulding's *Grand Hotel* (1932) and George Cukor's *Dinner at Eight* (1933), featuring John Barrymore, Greta Garbo, Joan Crawford, Wallace Beery, Jean Harlow, Marie Dressler, and other luminaries from their glittering roster of contract players. According to studio publicity, MGM had “more stars than there are in heaven.” Their more modest films still retained a high production gloss, such as the long-running Andy Hardy series, chronicling the small-town life and misadventures of an idealized American family, with a young Mickey Rooney starring as the family's irrepressible teenage son. Twentieth Century Fox came into its own with Henry King's *Lloyd's of London* (1936), starring Tyrone Power. Though Fox was always rather thin in star power, the studio created a vision of America as a great cultural melting pot, relying heavily on non-copyrighted songs of the late nineteenth century. Meanwhile, RKO Radio Pictures' *King Kong* (1933), directed by Merian C. Cooper and Ernest B. Schoedsack and with special effects by Willis H. O'Brien and his assistant, Marcel Delgado, made a



Willis H. O'Brien's spectacular stop-motion special effects work was the real star of Merian C. Cooper and Ernest B. Schoedsack's *King Kong* (1933).

fortune for the studio when it needed it most. In addition, RKO had a string of hits with the dance team of Fred Astaire and Ginger Rogers, beginning with Thornton Freeland's *Flying Down to Rio* (1933), which served as a tonic to the lavish effulgence of Busby Berkeley's anonymous, kaleidoscopic musical production numbers at Warners in such films as Mervyn LeRoy's *Gold Diggers of 1933*.

Performers were typically under contract for seven years, during which a studio would use its considerable resources to build a career, guiding players through a series of minor roles in modest films, along with singing, dancing, and acting classes, grooming them for their big breakthrough. For some, Hollywood stardom never came. The seven-year contracts were entirely one-sided; the studio had a six-month option clause and could terminate an actor's employment on the merest whim, or put someone on suspension for refusing to accept an inferior role, with the suspension period tacked onto the end of the seven-year term.

But for "A" list stars, such as Spencer Tracy, Bette Davis, James Cagney, Greta Garbo, and Joan Crawford, life was very good indeed. The studios mi-



A typically lavish Busby Berkeley production number ("We're in the Money") from Mervyn LeRoy's Depression-era musical *Gold Diggers of 1933* (1933).

cromanaged the stars' personal lives as well as their professional ones: dates were arranged between stars to publicize upcoming pictures, studios arranged low- or no-interest loans to purchase sprawling estates for the actors to reside in, and meals were served in the studio dining room to satisfy individual tastes.

At the same time, a morals clause in each star's contract, prohibiting wild parties, extramarital affairs, and the like, kept actors in line. In addition, directors, cameramen, composers, screenwriters, set designers, costumers, and other key personnel were under long-term contracts so that their services could easily be arranged for several pictures a year. The Hollywood studio system at its zenith was a true factory; in the 1930s and 1940s, a freelance director or star was a rarity. The studio's identity was defined by the stars it had under contract, the kinds of films it made, and the visual look of its product, the result of an army of designers and technicians behind the scenes.

PROBLEMS WITH EARLY SOUND

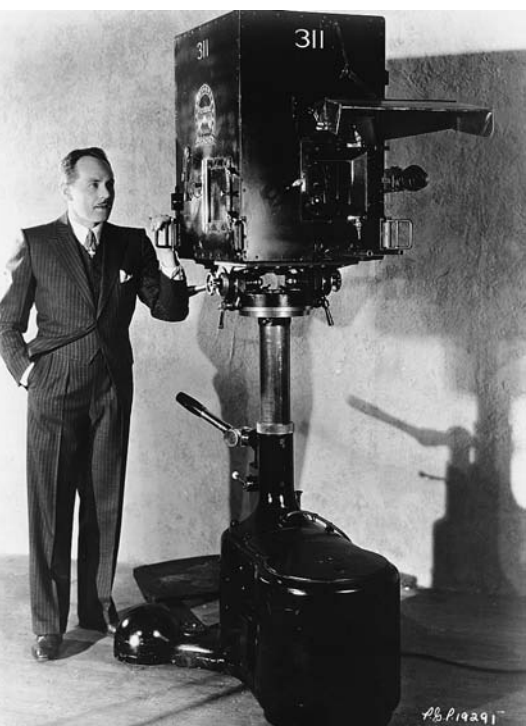
Technological advances during this period were numerous. The first microphones for recording sound were clumsy and bulky and produced poor

sound quality. Technicians insisted that the performers stand next to the microphones for optimal sound quality; this meant that both the camera and the actors stopped moving, resulting in static films that fans and critics alike derisively labeled “teacup drama.” Most actors in early sound films were recruited from Broadway; for those who did not have a good speaking voice, the parade was over. John Gilbert, one of the most famous stars of silent films, saw his career crumble because his high tenor voice didn’t mesh with the public perception of him as a dashing romantic hero (although rumors persist that his decline was the result of a feud with Louis B. Mayer). In the early days of sound, dubbing and mixing were all but impossible, so that many films were shot with multiple stationary cameras, each in a soundproof booth, while an orchestra played off screen so that all sound could be recorded simultaneously.

Not surprisingly, directors soon balked at these limitations, and audiences grew tired of films in which dialogue was the sole attraction. The early musicals of Ernst Lubitsch, such as *The Love Parade* (1929) and *Monte Carlo* (1930), used extensive post-synchronization to lay in music tracks after the film had been shot silently, allowing the camera to return to its state of mobility. Rouben Mamoulian, one of early sound film’s most audacious pioneers, was a proponent of the moving camera in such films as *Applause* (1929), *City Streets* (1931), and his masterpiece, *Dr. Jekyll and Mr. Hyde* (1931), still the most visually stimulating of the many versions of the classic tale. Soon cameras were mounted inside “blimps,” which soundproofed the noise of their running electric motors, and microphones were mounted on “booms,” long poles that were extended over the actors within a scene to allow mobility for the performers. Editing systems also improved, along with the introduction of separate sound and picture tracks that allowed cutters to freely manipulate the image and audio components of a film, as well as improvements in postproduction sound mixing and dubbing.



Tod Browning (sitting on rafter, left) directs John Gilbert in *The Show* (1927).



In the early 1930s, sound cameras were bulky and cumbersome.

GLORIOUS TECHNICOLOR

In 1935, Hollywood produced its first three-strip Technicolor feature film, Mamoulian's *Becky Sharp*. Three-strip Technicolor was a color additive process that exposed three separate strands of film in one gigantic camera, and then printed these three strands on top of one another to produce a full color effect. It was a vast improvement over the red and green pallor of "two-strip" Technicolor and the various stencil and dye processes that had been used since the medium's inception, in which film was run through a fixing bath and dyed one "color" for dramatic effect, or hand-colored frame by frame. Created by Herbert T. Kalmus, Technicolor soon became the dominant force in color films, and his company jealously guarded both its process and the equipment used to shoot Technicolor films. In fact, if a producer wanted to use Technicolor, he had to sign an agreement with the company to use Technicolor's camera and Technicolor's own house cameramen, and to employ Natalie Kalmus, Herbert's wife, as "color coordinator." Her taste ran to bold reds, vivid greens, and equally pronounced hues of all the other colors in the spectrum; pastels and shading were out.

If a producer or director argued about the use of color, Natalie Kalmus was quite willing to pull the plug on the whole project. Her sole function was to make sure that Technicolor showed itself to best advantage no matter what the subject matter, which accounts for the vibrancy of color in such classics of the period as *Gone with the Wind* and *The Wizard of Oz* (both 1939). At the same time, by the 1940s black-and-white cinematography had developed into a highly sophisticated art, with the introduction of more sensitive film and the adventurous lighting patterns pioneered by such brilliant cameramen as James Wong Howe, John Alton, Lee Garmes, Gregg Toland, and Nicholas Musuraca. Hollywood in the 1930s and 1940s was, on the whole, a rigidly defined genre factory, in which individual talents were tolerated and encouraged only as long as they added to the hegemony of the studio's hold on the public imagination.

JOHN FORD

Despite the fact that the studio moguls ran their empires like medieval kingdoms, using equal measures of fear, flattery, blandishments, and threats, some of the greatest directors in the history of cinema flourished under the Hollywood studio system. John Ford rapidly established himself as one of the industry's leading lights, specializing in westerns but working across a wide variety of genres. After many years in silent films beginning with *The Tornado* (1917), he scored his first sound success with a brilliant adaptation of Sinclair Lewis's novel *Arrowsmith* in 1931, about an idealistic doctor whose work leads him to question conventional medical ethics. In 1935, Ford directed the classic story of the IRA, *The Informer*, with Victor McLaglen, which again won him numerous plaudits. And yet Ford could direct a Shirley Temple feature such as *Wee Willie Winkie* (1937) with equal assurance, as well as the routine action picture *Submarine Patrol* (1938). In 1939, he directed the classic western *Stagecoach*, which made a star out of John Wayne. Wayne had been kicking around in films since the late 1920s; he and Ford struck up a friendship, and Ford subsequently recommended him for the leading role in Raoul Walsh's *The Big Trail* (1930), but the film failed to click at the box office. Wayne was then too inexperienced to command the audience's attention, and for the next nine years he struggled to make a living in a series of forgettable low-budget westerns, at one point even being pressed into service as a singing cowboy in the mold of Gene Autry and Roy Rogers, as "Singin' Sandy Saunders." Ford recognized that with a solid property and skillful direction, Wayne, older and wiser in 1939, would be ideal for the role of the Ringo Kid in *Stagecoach*, and the gamble paid off. As Wayne famously observed, Ford taught him not "how to act, but to react" to the other performers, to keep his gestures to a minimum, and to use his words sparingly.

Ford then went on to what many consider his finest film, *The Grapes of Wrath* (1940), based on John Steinbeck's novel about migrant farmers during the Depression. Henry Fonda, another of Ford's favorite actors, gives an



John Wayne (foreground) as the Ringo Kid in John Ford's classic western *Stagecoach* (1939).



Henry Fonda as Tom Joad in John Ford's *The Grapes of Wrath* (1940), one of the greatest films ever made about the effects of the Depression on American society.

understated and convincing portrayal of Tom Joad, forced with his family to search for a new beginning in a hostile landscape. When World War II came, Ford created several documentaries for the U.S. Navy before returning to civilian life with a string of classic westerns: *My Darling Clementine* (1946), *Fort Apache* (1948), *She Wore a Yellow Ribbon* (1949), and the masterful work *The Searchers* (1956), often cited, despite its often inherently racist depiction of Native Americans, as the perfect film.

Ford was one of the consummate studio directors, infusing simple material with his core values of duty, honor, and service to one's country. As a visual stylist, he preferred a rigidly stationary camera, known as the "information booth" style of direction, in which the actors enter a scene, play it out, and then exit, all in one take. His coverage of a scene is often simple, but his compositions are striking in their use of depth, light and shadow, and strategic camera placement. For many years, he shot most of his westerns in Monument Valley, Utah, using al-



John Wayne, John Ford, and Ben Johnson on the set of Ford's elegiac western *She Wore a Yellow Ribbon* (1949).



John Wayne and Jeffrey Hunter in John Ford's masterly western *The Searchers* (1956).

most the same location, so that a Ford western is instantly recognizable; fellow directors stayed away from Monument Valley as a sign of respect to him.

HOWARD HAWKS: THE GRAY FOX

Howard Hawks embraced a similar code of professionalism and moral conduct in his films, but Hawks was unique in the 1930s and 1940s because he refused to be tied down to one studio and worked in nearly every genre imaginable, from westerns to musicals, always with remarkable success. As producer of most of the films he directed, he kept a tight rein on the shooting process to ensure that everything was completed on time and under budget. Known as “the Gray Fox” because of his prematurely gray hair, as well as his skills as producer and director, Hawks often said that the key to a good film was simply “three good scenes, and no bad ones.” After a brief apprenticeship in the silent cinema, he broke out in 1930 with *The Dawn Patrol*, one of the great wartime aviation dramas. In 1930, working for independent producer Howard Hughes from a screenplay by former newspaperman Ben Hecht, Hawks directed *Scarface* (though it was not released until 1932), one of the most brutal gangster films of the early 1930s, loosely based on the life of Al Capone.

In 1934, Hawks created the quintessential screwball comedy *Twentieth Century*, starring John Barrymore and Carole Lombard, with Barrymore in



Cary Grant, “Baby” (the leopard), and Katharine Hepburn in Howard Hawks’s screwball classic *Bringing Up Baby* (1938).

top form as the egomaniacal theatrical producer Oscar Jaffe. *Bringing Up Baby* (1938) was another screwball classic and is considered one of Cary Grant and Katharine Hepburn’s finest films; “Baby” is Hepburn’s pet leopard, which gets both Grant and Hepburn in and out of a series of absurdist escapades. *His Girl Friday* (1940), a remake of Lewis Milestone’s comedy *The Front Page* (1931), teams Cary Grant and Rosalind Russell in a hard-boiled newspaper romance, notable for its cynicism and breakneck pace, as the players breathlessly rattle off their dialogue in record time.

After directing one of the great World War II dramas, *Air Force*, in 1943, Hawks, with the help of his wife, “discovered” Lauren Bacall and cast her opposite Humphrey Bogart in *To Have and Have Not* (1944). The chemistry between Bogart and Bacall was electric and carried over into real life; by 1946’s *The Big Sleep*, perhaps the finest hard-boiled detective film ever made, Bogart and Bacall were in the midst of a serious romance, much to Hawks’s displeasure (Bogart was married at the time, and Hawks, who had given Bacall the same nickname he used for his own wife, “Slim,” also had designs on the young actress). The intricate twists and double crosses in *The Big Sleep*, based on Raymond Chandler’s famous Philip Marlowe novel, were so complex that the screenwriters (novelist William Faulkner, Jules Furthman, and Leigh Brackett) sent a telegram to Chandler, asking for clarification on a particular murder in the film. Chandler replied that he had “no idea” who



had committed the crime, and the resulting film is a bewildering cross-hatch of murders, swindles, con games, and double-talk that both mystifies and enthralls the viewer.

Humphrey Bogart as Philip Marlowe (right) gets the drop on a stick-up man while Lauren Bacall, as Vivian Sternwood, looks on with admiration in Howard Hawks's complex murder mystery, *The Big Sleep* (1946).

As the war ended, Hawks embarked upon one of his most ambitious projects, *Red River* (1948), an epic western starring John Wayne and Montgomery Clift. The movie raised the western to a new level of sophistication, and Wayne's brutal portrayal of a psychotic trail boss who will do anything to get his cattle to market surprised even John Ford, who saw the film and then told Hawks, "I didn't know the s.o.b. could *act*." Hawks's films are all shot through with a sense of grace under pressure, a certain fatalism in human interactions, and the idea that "a man has to know his limitations." In addition, Hawks pioneered the pre-feminist concept of the "Hawksian Woman," a strong female protagonist who refuses to buckle under to men, is perfectly capable of taking care of herself, and operates smoothly in what Hawks clearly views as a man's world.

HITCHCOCK IN HOLLYWOOD

Meanwhile, Alfred Hitchcock continued his string of suspense classics in England with *The 39 Steps* (1935), *Secret Agent* (1936), *Sabotage* (1936), and



Robert Donat and Madeleine Carroll in Alfred Hitchcock's breakthrough thriller, *The 39 Steps* (1935).

The Lady Vanishes (1938) before accepting an offer from producer David O. Selznick to come to Hollywood and direct *Rebecca* (1940), based on Daphne du Maurier's novel. The film was an immediate box office and critical success, and Hitchcock's American career was launched. Describing the facilities at American studios as "incomparably better" than those he had used in England, Hitchcock began a long string of deeply personal films superficially masquerading as thrillers.

Shadow of a Doubt (1943), with a superb performance from Joseph Cotten as a compulsive murderer of wealthy widows, was followed by *Lifeboat* (1944), a stylistic tour de force in which the surviving passengers of a sunken ship struggle against the elements and each other's jealousies and fears. *Spellbound* (1945) is a psychological murder mystery with a

dream sequence choreographed by Salvador Dalí. *Rope* (1948) is the chilling story of two young men who strangle one of their friends and then host a party in which food is served on the trunk containing the dead body. What makes *Rope* so intriguing is that it consists exclusively of lengthy tracking shots, often up to ten minutes long, in which Hitchcock's camera dollies smoothly around the killers' New York penthouse, allowing the tragic narrative to play out in real time with only a handful of edit points in the entire film.

Hitchcock was one of the first directors to have his name above the title as a key selling point, and he is among the few directors whose films almost constitute a genre unto themselves, the suspense-filled "Hitchcock thriller" (similarly, a "Ford western"). A meticulous planner, he storyboarded each of his films from first shot to last before a single foot of film was exposed; he liked to say that this was his favorite part of making a film, because the actual shooting was often boring and laborious.

Hitchcock's most frequent leading men were Cary Grant and James Stewart, actors who could fend for themselves in front of the camera and who traded largely on their own screen personae to bring a role to life. Taciturn



A motley group of survivors faces the perils of the ocean in Alfred Hitchcock's *Lifeboat* (1944), a parable about the need for personal responsibility in wartime.

on the set, Hitchcock drove some of his actors to distraction with his aloof, distanced approach; during the remake of *The Man Who Knew Too Much* (1956), Doris Day almost quit because the director refused to provide any feedback on the set. Finally confronted about his seeming indifference, Hitchcock looked deeply surprised and told Day that no comment from him was necessary, as she was giving “just what I wanted” in her performance. This detachment from the shooting process allowed him to design his films as intricate puzzles that hook the audience with clever and exciting touches.

FRITZ LANG IN AMERICA

Fritz Lang picked up his career in America after his rapid departure from Nazi Germany with *Fury* (1936), an anti-lynching melodrama starring Spencer Tracy. Lang originally wanted the protagonist, the intended victim of the film, to be African American, in order to expose the vicious racism he had observed in the American South. Although he fought with his studio bosses at MGM “like a Trojan,” in his own words, he was simply ahead of his time. The film is still a ringing indictment of small-town narrow-mindedness and prejudice. Lang found it difficult initially to work on a Hollywood set—he saw no reason to stop for lunch or dinner if a scene was going well,

and rapidly alienated his star, and much of his crew, with his dictatorial attitude—but he soon adjusted to the studio system and became one of Hollywood's most personal, if pessimistic, stylists. After *You Only Live Once* (1937), a superb drama in which Henry Fonda, as an ex-convict, tries to go straight but finds that the deck is stacked against him, Lang was assigned to two Technicolor westerns at Twentieth Century Fox, *The Return of Frank James* (1940) and the epic *Western Union* (1941). When Fox's studio chief questioned whether or not Lang could persuasively handle the material, the director replied that the western was America's great mythic saga, as *Die Nibelungen* was Germany's, and that he felt entirely at home with the epic sweep of the material.

Lang directed the anti-Nazi action drama *Hangmen Also Die* (1943) and went on to make three of his most suspenseful and unremittingly fatalistic films in a two-year blaze of creativity: *Ministry of Fear* (1944), *The Woman in the Window* (1945), and *Scarlet Street* (1945). Ray Milland stars in *Ministry of Fear* as a mental patient caught in a web of espionage, but given his unbalanced state no one will believe him when he tries to go to the authorities. *The Woman in the Window* and *Scarlet Street* have identical casts, and nearly the same plot: 1940s tough-guy Dan Duryea, seductress Joan Bennett, and Edward G. Robinson, cast against type as a mild-mannered victim of Duryea and Bennett's machinations. All three films represent high points in the genre of film noir, a moody, pessimistic style of filming with downbeat plots, unscrupulous protagonists, and dark, atmospheric cinematography that reflected the social malaise and unease of postwar American society. In all these films, Lang developed his view of humanity as essentially flawed, foredoomed, and inherently corruptible.

CHAPLIN IN THE 1930S

As late as 1936, with *Modern Times*, Charles Chaplin was still making silent films with musical accompaniment and sound effects, although that film borrows perhaps too freely from René Clair's early sound masterpiece *À Nous la liberté* (1931); both are satires on the dehumanization of the factory assembly line, though Clair's vision is more romantic and whimsical. Working at his own studio, Chaplin created *The Great Dictator* (1940), the first film in which the Little Tramp character was given a voice. A courageous satire of Hitler, the film initially failed to find favor with the public, perhaps in part because it appeared before the United States entered World War II. Chaplin's final films—*Monsieur Verdoux* (1947), a dark comedy about a serial killer



with Chaplin in the title role; *Limelight* (1952), a backstage melodrama; *A King in New York* (1957), a mild political satire reflecting Chaplin's disenchantment with the Cold War; and *A Countess from Hong Kong* (1967), a gently amusing farce shot in England and teaming Marlon Brando and Sophia Loren—form a quiet coda to Chaplin's great work as an auteur.

[LEFT]: Charles Chaplin starred in his own satire on mechanized society, *Modern Times* (1936). [RIGHT]: Charles Chaplin as Adenoid Hynkel, the power-mad dictator of Tomania, in Chaplin's spoof of Hitler, *The Great Dictator* (1940).

THE LUBITSCH TOUCH

Ernst Lubitsch, as we have seen, began with a series of sophisticated sex comedies in Germany, but unlike Lang he left long before the Nazis came to power. By 1924, he was directing *The Marriage Circle* for Warner Bros. and then moved over to Paramount, where he created his most enduring masterpieces in the 1930s: *The Love Parade* (1929), *The Smiling Lieutenant* (1931), *One Hour with You* (1932, which was begun by director George Cukor), and the sublime *Trouble in Paradise* (1932), all romantic comedies with a bite. Lubitsch used the French music hall star Maurice Chevalier in many of his early films, perhaps most memorably in *One Hour with You* as a doctor caught in a romantic triangle with his wife and her best friend. Lubitsch's style is incom-



Kay Francis, Miriam Hopkins, and Herbert Marshall in Ernst Lubitsch's classic sound comedy *Trouble in Paradise* (1932).

parably light and graceful, and he found ways to suggest sex that smoothly avoided censorship, such as having the shadows of two lovers' heads appear on the pillowcase of their bed to suggest conjugal bliss; such visual tropes, coupled with the director's playful approach to relationships between men and women, gave the director's films what many called "the Lubitsch Touch." In *Trouble in Paradise*, jewel thieves plan to fleece a rich woman out of her wealth, but a romantic triangle disrupts their plans; the film ends with the intended robbery thwarted and the thieves reunited in love and larceny. The essence of Lubitsch is to make the potentially tragic seem as effervescent as a glass of champagne; although perils and heartbreak confront his characters, their elegance and style see them through the most potentially compromising situations.

As World War II approached, Lubitsch directed Greta Garbo in *Ninotchka* (1939), a sophisticated comedy of manners in which Garbo plays a humorless Soviet emissary who falls in love with both capitalism and Melvyn Douglas. *The Shop Around the Corner* (1940), a romantic comedy drama about two workers in a Budapest shop who unwittingly fall in love via the mail, although they detest each other in everyday life, is a typically charming Lubitsch film of mistaken identity, remade by Nora Ephron as *You've Got Mail* (1998).

One of Lubitsch's finest works was *To Be or Not to Be* (1942), a satire of the Nazis with Jack Benny hilariously cast as "that great, great Polish actor, Joseph Tura," involved in a plot to save the Polish underground while his

wife fools around with a young lieutenant on the side. As a Shakespearean actor within the film, Benny makes an utterly unlikely Hamlet, and Lubitsch keeps the pace moving crisply in this trenchant piece of social commentary. Surprisingly, it was a commercial failure when first released. In the midst of war, it seems, Hitler was too serious a foe to lampoon for general audiences; in hindsight, *To Be or Not to Be* is one of Lubitsch's most accomplished farces and the highlight of Jack Benny's screen career. In 1943, Lubitsch directed his first color production, the romantic comedy *Heaven Can Wait*, in which an aging roué thinks back over his life of romantic alliances as he is cross-examined by Satan to see whether he belongs in Hell. In all, Lubitsch's care-free attitude toward life, romance, and the battle of the sexes made him an anomaly in Hollywood; although he was an efficient businessman (and for a time the head of production at Paramount), he remained at heart a Continental sophisticate, most at home in a world of gentle romance and light-hearted sexual comedy.

MAX OPHÜLS

If Lubitsch saw the relationship between men and women as a playful battle of wits and whims, Max Ophüls was perhaps the supreme romanticist of the movies, both in his early work in Germany and his later work in the United States. Ophüls did not make a great many films, but his work is marked by a deeply suffused sense of Old World romance and lost splendor. His most famous American film is *Letter from an Unknown Woman* (1948), starring Joan Fontaine and Louis Jourdan in the tale of a young woman who is seduced and abandoned by a brilliant young concert pianist and finds herself alone and pregnant. The story, like most of Ophüls's work, takes place in the nineteenth century, in a zone of memory and nostalgia that renders the viewer spellbound. Ophüls is most noted for his luxurious camera movement, maintaining constant motion throughout often lengthy and complex shots. James Mason, who starred in Ophüls's 1949 melodrama *Caught*, was deeply amused by the director's ceaselessly roving camera setups, and composed a poem in Ophüls's honor, which read in part:

A shot that does not call for tracks
Is agony for poor, dear Max
Once, when they took away his crane
I thought he'd never smile again.



Adventuress Lola Montès (Martine Carol) becomes part of a circus sideshow as Peter Ustinov (lower left) looks on in Max Ophüls's final film, *Lola Montès* (1955).

Ophüls himself noted that “life for me is movement,” and a sense of fluid restlessness pervades all his best work. His crowning achievement is undoubtedly *Lola Montès* (1955), a French/West German co-production that recounts the affair of a famous adventuress with King Ludwig I of Bavaria. Shot in dazzling CinemaScope and riotous color, the film cost a then-staggering \$3.5 million and was initially, like so many films ahead of their time, a failure at the box office. Much to Ophüls's dismay, the film was then ruthlessly recut and released in the United States under the sensationalistic title *The Sins of Lola Montès*, in a cheap black-and-white version that ruined his masterly color design. Seen today in its original version, the film is an overwhelming experience, a romance of such lavish and epic proportions that it literally confounds the senses.

ORSON WELLES IN HOLLYWOOD

Orson Welles began in the theater as a “boy wonder,” then drifted into radio dramas in New York in the 1930s by playing “The Shadow” and other popular characters. It was then that he founded the Mercury Theatre Company,

which produced plays on Broadway and on the radio with scandalous success. His 30 October 1938 radio adaptation of H. G. Wells's *War of the Worlds* was his ticket to international fame, or infamy; designed as a breaking news story, Welles's production convinced millions of listeners that Martians were invading the earth, landing en masse in Grover's Mill, New Jersey. There was immediate, widespread panic: churches were jammed with terrified citizens as people prayed for deliverance from the alien onslaught. The second half of the hour-long broadcast made it clear that the entire story was, indeed, fiction, but Welles's brilliant use of the medium had so unnerved the nation that he was summarily forced to apologize for the riots he had caused.

Sensing that he would do just as well in the cinema as he had on stage and in radio, RKO Pictures signed Welles to direct in 1939. Once in Hollywood, Welles locked himself in a screening room for months, taking a self-imposed crash course in cinematic technique, aided by the brilliant cinematographer Gregg Toland. After considering and then abandoning a film adaptation of Joseph Conrad's *Heart of Darkness* (which would have used first-person camera work to force the audience to identify with the protagonist), he settled on a thinly fictionalized life of the notorious yellow journalist William Randolph Hearst. Hearst was an immensely rich and powerful man who controlled much of the nation's media, with a string of newspapers, radio stations, and even a film production company that existed primarily to provide star vehicles for Hearst's longtime mistress, Marion Davies. Welles saw Hearst's career as a tragic example of overreaching, and *Citizen Kane* (1941) is thus the story of a man who has greatness and wealth thrust upon him and then destroys himself and all those around him—friends, wives, business associates—with his greed, thirst for power, and egomania.

Citizen Kane is justifiably one of the most famous works in cinema history. As a debut film (Welles was just twenty-five years old when he began shooting) *Kane* is all the more extraordinary. Welles served as co-writer (with Herman Mankiewicz) and director and also played the Hearst character, Charles Foster Kane, in what would be the greatest performance of his long career. In addition, he kept the production on a tight schedule, contrary to persistent rumors at the time. He even used screen-test footage from the famous breakfast table sequence with Ruth Warrick in the final print, and in the end brought the entire film in for well under a million dollars.

But in his youth and brashness, Welles had not reckoned with Hearst's considerable power and influence. After seeing the film, Hearst used his papers' top gossip columnist, Louella Parsons, to threaten the entire Holly-



[LEFT] Orson Welles (left, pointing) and cameraman Gregg Toland (seated, legs crossed) on the set of Welles's *Citizen Kane* (1941). [RIGHT] A heroic angle shot from Orson Welles's *Citizen Kane* (1941).



wood studio system with a series of embarrassing revelations about the private lives of its top stars unless the negative and all prints of *Kane* were destroyed. A consortium of studio heads offered Welles and RKO a million dollars to destroy the movie, but to their eternal credit RKO refused to negotiate and released the film, uncut, to rave reviews. The film, tracing Kane's life from an unhappy childhood to old age and death through a series of complicated flashbacks, was a masterpiece of set design, camera placement, deep-focus composition, lighting, and editing. Indeed, critical acclaim for *Kane* was overwhelming, especially in Europe and the rest of the world, yet the movie did poorly at the box office. In addition, the film predictably brought down the wrath of the Hearst organization on RKO, which now found itself banned from all Hearst newspapers, both in reviews and advertising. As a result, RKO became invisible to millions of Hearst readers, and Welles acquired a reputation for being a brilliant but difficult and potentially dangerous filmmaker. He would never again have the freedom he had enjoyed on *Citizen Kane*.

Welles's second feature, *The Magnificent Ambersons* (1942), about the de-

cline and fall of a prosperous midwestern family, featured many of the members of the Mercury Theatre unit. Welles's original cut ran 148 minutes, but the studio was no longer willing to accommodate the young director as they had in the past. The film was taken out of his hands and savagely recut to eighty-eight minutes by the film's editor, Robert Wise (later a solid director in his own right), and a happy ending was hastily shot and tacked on to satisfy audiences, who had reacted negatively to the original version in previews. Demonstrating their new attitude toward Welles, RKO released the mutilated version of *Ambersons* on the bottom half of a double bill with Leslie Goodwins's program comedy *Mexican Spitfire Sees a Ghost* (1942).

Welles's career never really recovered, although he displayed flashes of brilliance in his subsequent films and went on to a long career as an actor, voiceover artist, and commercial pitchman. His 1943 production of *Journey into Fear* for RKO was also taken out of his hands, and the film was completed by a former Welles collaborator. Though but a scant sixty-eight minutes, *Journey into Fear* is still talky and tedious, almost entirely devoid of Welles's signature bravura style.

Only two years after his spectacular debut as an auteur, Welles saw his directing career slipping away. It was not until 1946 that he was allowed to direct again, when independent producer Sam Spiegel (then known as S. P. Eagle) agreed to finance the shooting of the modest suspense melodrama *The Stranger*. Welles also stars in the picture as an ex-Nazi in hiding after the war, teaching at a small college in Connecticut. The film went off smoothly during production, but Welles hated the result, calling it "the worst of my films."

Nevertheless, it was a solid commercial success, and at Columbia Pictures Harry Cohn decided to give Welles a shot at directing, starring in, and co-writing *The Lady from Shanghai* (1947), an overheated suspense thriller starring Welles's wife, the glamorous Rita Hayworth. Shooting dragged on for months, as the director supervised location shooting in Mexico and New York City to bring his fevered vision to the screen. When he delivered his final cut, Cohn and the Columbia brass found it incoherent and bizarre (as it is), but they missed the film's originality and quirky brilliance. Substantially recut, the film was shuffled into theaters with a minimum of fanfare, where it failed miserably.

The only studio in Hollywood that would hire Welles now, after long negotiations, turned out to be Republic Pictures, best known for its westerns and Saturday morning serials. Welles then turned out his version of *Macbeth* (1948), a bold attempt to visualize the play in long takes on stark, minimalist

A SHORT HISTORY OF FILM

sets, but his insistence that the actors perform with thick Scottish accents rendered much of the sound track incomprehensible. His last American film was also one of his best, the dark *Touch of Evil* (1958), which the studio (Universal in this case) again took out of his hands and reedited over Welles's objections. (The film has been restored to the director's original cut and is available on DVD.)

Hollywood was now finished with Welles, but he continued making a series of increasingly marginalized films on shoestring budgets in Europe. His brief Hollywood career, as incandescent as it was, had lasted only seven years, from 1941 to 1948. Still, despite the few films he produced during this period and the continued studio interference he faced, his films display a coherent vision of a world in which absolute power corrupts absolutely; as a visual stylist, his pyrotechnical use of the camera and editing are matched only by Eisenstein.

FRANK CAPRA'S SMALL-TOWN AMERICA

Frank Capra followed up the success of 1934's *It Happened One Night* with a string of sentimental films about small-town American values, which the director himself dubbed "Capra corn." *Lost Horizon* (1937), an atypical trip to exotica for the director, was a critical and financial disappointment, but in such films as *You Can't Take It with You* (1938), *Mr. Smith Goes to Washington* (1939), *Meet John Doe* (1941), and his now classic *It's a Wonderful Life* (1946), Capra extolled the virtues of the common man over the machinations of bankers and corporate interests, creating a comforting world of

The idealistic senator (James Stewart) breaks down in the climax of Frank Capra's *Mr. Smith Goes to Washington* (1939).



working-class, populist values that audiences readily identified with. For most observers, Capra's early films remain his finest work.

In addition to his feature films, during World War II Capra produced and directed the *Why We Fight* series of documentary/propaganda films at the behest of President Franklin Roosevelt to explain to the public the reasons for the U.S. entry into the conflict. The first of these, *Prelude to War* (1943), created the pattern that the rest of the series would follow: a mix of documentary footage, animation, and staged sequences shot in Hollywood to create a compelling blend of images that bolstered the wartime home-front morale.

But as the 1940s rolled on, Capra seemed out of step with the rest of the nation, which had been socially transformed by the war. *It's a Wonderful Life* wasn't a box office hit when first released, as audiences flocked instead to such films as William Wyler's *The Best Years of Our Lives* (1946) for a more realistic vision of life in postwar America. Indeed, the failure of *It's a Wonderful Life* put an end to Capra's independent film company, and his subsequent career was marginal.

GEORGE CUKOR

George Cukor was known in the trade as a "woman's director" because of his skill in directing such stars as Katharine Hepburn, but his credits range over a wide variety of genres. *A Bill of Divorcement* (1932) was Hepburn's screen debut, as the daughter of a man who has been committed to an insane asylum for many years and then returns home to find that his wife has left him for another man. *Dinner at Eight* (1933) is, along with Edmund Goulding's *Grand Hotel* (1932), the definitive all-star film, a shrewd combination of comedy and drama centering on the lives of a group of ambitious Manhattan socialites. *David Copperfield* (1935) is a faithful adaptation of Dickens's classic novel and offered W. C. Fields his only serious role as the perennially bankrupt Mr. Micawber. *Gaslight* (1944), one of the screen's great melodramas, stars Charles Boyer as a husband who contrives to drive his wife (Ingrid Bergman) mad so that he can have her declared insane and gain control of her fortune. Cukor also directed the classic comedy of the sexes *The Philadelphia Story* (1940), with Hepburn, James Stewart, and Cary Grant, and teamed Hepburn and Spencer Tracy in *Adam's Rib* (1949) and *Pat and Mike* (1952). The show business drama *A Star Is Born* (1954), with Judy Garland and James Mason, suffered massive cuts when first released, yet is now

recognized as a classic examination of the mechanics of the star system, the Hollywood studio system, and the evanescent nature of celebrity. In all, Cukor's career spanned over five decades; his later works are highlighted in Chapter 8.

“ONE-TAKE” WOODY

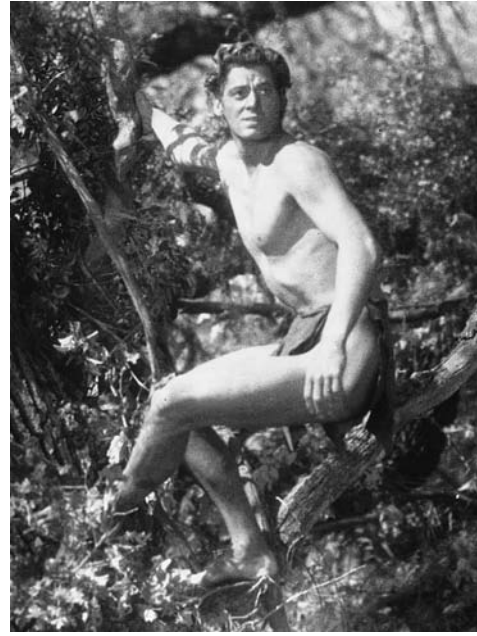
W. S. Van Dyke often filmed rehearsals and printed them for inclusion in the final film, allowing him to complete shooting in as little as twelve days. One such film was *The Thin Man* (1934), the first in a series of sparkling comedies starring William Powell and Myrna Loy as Nick and Nora Charles, sophisticated, wealthy Manhattanites who solve murder cases as a hobby. Van Dyke also directed the first major studio film shot on location in Africa, *Trader Horn* (1931); a series of Tarzan films based on Edgar Rice Burroughs's novels, beginning with *Tarzan the Ape Man* (1932), starring Johnny Weissmuller; the epic film on the 1906 earthquake, *San Francisco* (1936); and the lavish costume spectacle *Marie Antoinette* (1938). A jack-of-all-trades, Van Dyke was one of MGM's most dependable house directors, and his early death in 1943 cut short a career that was really just getting started.

Myrna Loy and William Powell as Nick and Nora Charles in W. S. Van Dyke's surprise mystery/comedy hit, *The Thin Man* (1934).





[LEFT] Myrna Loy (extreme left) watches as William Powell toasts director W. S. Van Dyke on the set of *The Thin Man* (1934). [RIGHT] Johnny Weissmuller in the title role of W. S. Van Dyke's *Tarzan the Ape Man* (1932).



SPECTACLE: DEMILLE AND VON STERNBERG

Cecil B. DeMille remained the screen's foremost purveyor of spectacle. His early sound films, such as *Sign of the Cross* (1932), with Charles Laughton as Nero idly plucking his harp while Rome burns, and *Cleopatra* (1934), starring Claudette Colbert, are both sumptuous and licentious; as usual, DeMille missed no opportunity for pageantry and stylized debauchery on his way to the inevitable moralistic ending. As the 1930s progressed, DeMille could be counted on to produce eye-filling, big-budget crowd pleasers such as *The Crusades* (1934), *The Buccaneer* (1938), *Union Pacific* (1939), and *Samson and Delilah* (1949). Many critics have remarked that the true star of all DeMille's films was the director himself, who subordinated the narrative concerns of his works to an almost manic compulsion to pile excess upon excess, until the frames of his films fairly explode with action, spectacle, and armies of anonymous extras.

Josef von Sternberg's calculated exoticism made an overnight Depression-era star out of Marlene Dietrich, beginning with their first collaboration, *Der Blaue Engel* (*The Blue Angel*, 1930), which cast Dietrich as a glamorous seductress who brings about the ruin of a pathetic schoolmaster. Using an intoxicating mixture of light and shadow, von Sternberg's camera



Clive Brook and Marlene Dietrich in Josef von Sternberg's exotic *Shanghai Express* (1932).

lingers on Dietrich in such films as *Dishonored* (1931), *Shanghai Express* (1932), *Blonde Venus* (1932), and *The Scarlet Empress* (1934), caressing her body with a simmering bath of incandescent illumination and exotic costumes. Plot and incident are secondary in these films, which really exist to glorify Dietrich's alluring presence, even as they acknowledge her androgynous sexuality (Dietrich kisses a woman on the mouth in *Morocco* [1930]). Dreamlike, ornate, and meticulous down to the last detail, von Sternberg's best films are ultimately a meditation on the power of the constructed image of sexual temptation.

PRESTON STURGES

Preston Sturges emerged as the foremost social satirist of the period. He began his career in 1930, writing dialogue for Paramount. After a stint as a Broadway playwright, he convinced the studio to let him direct *The Great McGinty* (1940). The film's critical and commercial success allowed Sturges to carve out a unique career as both director and writer. Films such as *Sulli-*

van's Travels (1941) and *The Miracle of Morgan's Creek* (1944) effectively punctured the manners and social conventions of the era, using a madcap array of characters stuck in a series of improbable situations to convey the cheerful chaos of everyday existence. *Hail the Conquering Hero* (1944), in typical Sturges fashion, is edgier than standard wartime comedies, satirizing the cult of heroism in its story of a marine reject who is mistaken for a war hero in his hometown. Other Sturges films allowed space for the creativity of his leading ladies to shine. *Palm Beach Story* (1942) stars Claudette Colbert as a loving wife who leaves her impecunious husband and then gets mixed up with a wacky and wealthy family in Florida. Similarly, *The Lady Eve* (1941) features Barbara Stanwyck as a con artist who attempts to scam a wealthy but simple Henry Fonda, only to fall in love, break up, and ultimately exact her revenge. Widely praised as the most brilliant satires in Hollywood, Sturges's movies were compared to those of Capra and Lubitsch. No one since has duplicated his sophisticated screwball style.

THE HOLLYWOOD PROFESSIONALS

Besides these major directors, a veritable army of skilled journeymen were trained to handle everyday directorial assignments. The studios supervised the careers of not only their actors, but also their directors, cinematographers, and other key creative personnel, acting as a sort of finishing school for talent in support of the system. Directors often advanced to their positions from the cutting room, where they learned how to put a film together from the "coverage," or footage that had been shot for each film they were assigned to edit. Such directors included William A. Wellman, known as "Wild Bill" for his rough manner and habit of carrying a gun on the sets to emphasize his authority; he created hard-hitting gangster films such as *The Public Enemy* (1931), which made a star of James Cagney. Indeed, for one of the key sequences in the film, Wellman insisted that real machine-gun bullets be used to blast away a section of a brick wall, just moments after Cagney had ducked behind it. Wellman also directed a variety of other films, including *A Star Is Born*, examining the vagaries of Hollywood, and the biting comedy *Nothing Sacred* (both 1937).

Frank Borzage, one of the most underrated directors of the 1930s and 1940s, scored his first big hit with the silent melodrama *Humoresque* (1920). His style is often dismissed as deeply sentimental, but he won an Academy Award for *Seventh Heaven* (1927) and went on to create, among many other



James Cagney offers Mae Clarke some grapefruit in William A. Wellman's *The Public Enemy* (1931).

works, the Hemingway adaptation *A Farewell to Arms* (1932), *Little Man What Now?* (1934), about the rise of Fascism in Germany, the charming musical *Flirtation Walk* (1934), the religious drama *The Green Light* (1937), and the lavish biblical spectacle *The Big Fisherman* (1959). Borzage emerges as a conscientious craftsman who always brought to his material an extra measure of dignity, coupled with a fluid visual style that extracted the most from his performers.

Mervyn LeRoy, another deeply underrated auteur, specialized in hard-boiled films, such as *Little Caesar* (1931), which catapulted Edward G. Robinson to stardom. LeRoy directed an astonishing six films in 1932,

including *I Am a Fugitive from a Chain Gang*, an exposé of prison gang conditions in the southern United States; *Three on a Match*, a sordid tale of adultery, kidnapping, drug abuse, and alcoholism; and *Two Seconds*, in which a convict sees his entire life flash before his eyes in the time it takes to execute him.

William Witney became the foremost action specialist in Hollywood, and his rise to the director's chair is typical of the era. Witney began in films as a messenger boy, and after years of work he found a position at Republic as a script supervisor. In 1937, after much lobbying with the front office, Witney began to direct serials, often paired with director John English. Their partnership became the best directorial team in sound action serials, creating chapter-plays such as *The Adventures of Captain Marvel* and *Dick Tracy vs. Crime, Inc.* (both 1941). The serials were shot quickly and economically, costing \$200,000 to \$300,000 apiece, with shooting schedules of thirty to forty days. Witney was also the person who created modern choreographed fight scenes; he learned how to plan and block a movie fight by watching how Busby Berkeley constructed his dance numbers on the sets of his 1930s musicals. Serials were made by a group of talented professionals working at a furious pace, doing at least fifty to sixty setups in a typical day. In terms of

stunt choreography, miniature work, camera work, and narrative pacing, Witney and English have influenced a whole new generation of action filmmakers, especially Steven Spielberg and George Lucas, who would pioneer the big-screen blockbuster “comic book” film in the mid-1970s.

Allan Dwan began as a filmmaker in 1911, directing hundreds of pictures for a variety of studios during the silent era. When sound came in, Dwan made the transition effortlessly. He directed the very successful Dumas adaptation *The Three Musketeers* (1939) and the very funny sex comedy *Getting Gertie's Garter* (1945), way ahead of its time in its realistic view of marriage and infidelity. Other notable Dwan films include *Sands of Iwo Jima* (1949), one of the finest movies produced at Republic, and *The Woman They Almost Lynched* (1953), in which Joan Leslie learns to defend herself in a violent frontier town, only to be set upon by the traditional male hierarchy for overstepping a woman's role. Dwan is important because he managed to immerse himself completely in his projects and never allowed his style to impose itself on his material. At the same time, the quiet assurance of Dwan's mise-en-scène is evident in all his work, which is remarkable for its modesty as well as its self-assurance.

Edward Dmytryk came to prominence in the late 1940s as one of the key architects of the postwar genre of film noir (literally “black film”), offering a cynical view of humankind. Dmytryk's breakthrough effort was the Boris Karloff horror film *The Devil Commands* (1941), an interesting and offbeat entry in which Karloff attempts to contact the spirit of his dead wife who has been killed in an automobile accident. The micro-budgeted *Hitler's Children* (1943), a lurid tale of the Hitler Youth, featuring forced sterilizations and the requisite amount of goose-stepping, was one of the top-grossing films of that year. By the mid-1940s, Dmytryk had moved on to “A” pictures such as the detective thrillers *Murder My Sweet* (1944) and *Cornered* (1945), as well as the war film *Back to Bataan* (1945) and the wartime romance *Till the End of Time* (1946). During this period, he also developed his signature lighting technique of simply splashing one light on the wall of a set and letting the shadows dominate the frame. This dark, evocative method perfectly suited the subject matter of Dmytryk's darker films, and, as he noted, it also saved time.

Raoul Walsh chronicled the rise and inevitable fall of gangster James Cagney in *The Roaring Twenties* (1939), and the last days of the tragic bank robber Roy Earle (Humphrey Bogart) in *High Sierra* (1941). Walsh was equally at home with war films, as he proved in *Objective, Burma!* (1945), and comedy/fantasy outings, as in the underrated *The Horn Blows at Midnight* (1945), featuring Jack Benny as the angel Gabriel, dispatched to earth



Gangster Cody Jarrett (James Cagney) goes out with guns blazing in the ferocious conclusion of Raoul Walsh's brutal crime drama *White Heat* (1949).

to sound the trumpet announcing the end of the world. Walsh's most enduring achievement, however, is the brutal gangster melodrama *White Heat* (1949), in which psychopathic gangster Cody Jarrett (Cagney) relies upon his mother to keep his gang in line, as he blasts his way from one violent stickup to the next without a shred of conscience.

Jacques Tourneur, working for producer Val Lewton's horror unit at RKO, turned out some of the era's most inventive and atmospheric horror films, far removed from the Universal Studios formula of the Wolfman, Frankenstein's monster, and Dracula. The groundbreaking thriller *Cat People* (1942) tells the tale of a young woman who turns into a leopard when she is sexually aroused. Tourneur makes the film's preposterous premise both believable and ominous; among the many memorable set pieces is an attack on a woman in a deserted swimming pool at night, photographed almost entirely in darkness. Tourneur followed this effort with his Gothic masterpiece *I Walked with a Zombie* (1943), another Lewton production, which transported *Jane Eyre* to the West Indies, and

Tourneur's masterpiece, the noir classic *Out of the Past* (1947), a convoluted tale of greed, murder, and betrayal.

After fleeing Nazi Germany, genre stylist Robert Siodmak landed a contract at Universal starting at \$150 a week and directed one of the best war-time horror films, *Son of Dracula* (1943), starring Lon Chaney Jr. By the end of the war, however, the classic Universal monsters had reached the end of their collective tether, with the production of Erle C. Kenton's films *House of Frankenstein* (1944) and *House of Dracula* (1945), which teamed up Dracula, the Wolfman, and the Frankenstein monster in a vain attempt to revive flagging audience interest. By 1948, the monsters were being used as comedy

foils in *Abbott and Costello Meet Frankenstein*, and it would be a decade before the next great cycle of horror films would emerge, this time in Britain, at Hammer Studios.

At PRC, the smallest studio in Hollywood, *maudit* director Edgar G. Ulmer, whom we last saw working with Fred Zinnemann, Billy Wilder, and Robert Siodmak on *People on Sunday* in Germany in 1930, directed films at a furious pace to create the noir classics *Girls in Chains* (1943), *Bluebeard* (about the famous serial killer of women, 1944), *Strange Illusion* (a modern-day version of *Hamlet*, 1945), and *Detour* (1945), considered by many to be the ultimate noir. Pianist Al Roberts (Tom Neal) hitchhikes to Los Angeles from New York to be with his erstwhile fiancée, Sue (Claudia Drake), who has abandoned him to pursue dreams of stardom in the film capital. On the way to Hollywood, Roberts hitches a ride with a fast-talking hymnal salesman, Charles Haskell (Edmund MacDonald), who abruptly dies. Roberts assumes Haskell's identity, but then picks up Vera (Ann Savage), who had thumbed a ride with Haskell earlier and realizes that Roberts is a fraud. From here, things rapidly become more and more complicated, as Vera blackmails Roberts, threatening to go to the police and implicate Roberts as Haskell's murderer if he fails to obey her slightest whim. Shot in five days on a few spare sets and an astoundingly low \$30,000, *Detour* has become an American classic, effectively portraying the hopelessness and despair of a rootless existence on the road.

John Huston, who would go on to greater triumphs as a director in the 1950s and 1960s, made an auspicious debut with the classic crime thriller *The Maltese Falcon* (1941), starring Humphrey Bogart, Peter Lorre, Sydney Greenstreet, and Mary Astor. His later films in the 1940s included *Across the Pacific* (1942), a wartime thriller that reteamed Bogart, Astor, and Greenstreet; the World War II documentary *The Battle of San Pietro* (1945), which showed frontline combat with a realism hitherto unapproached by the cinema; *The Treasure of the Sierra Madre* (1948), a rousing adventure film, starring Walter Huston (John's father) and Bogart in a tale of gold and greed in the Mexican mountains; and *Key Largo* (1948), one of the last great gangster films from Hollywood's Golden Age, again with Bogart, teamed with Bacall (now his wife) and co-starring Edward G. Robinson as aging crime boss Johnny Rocco. With just these few films, Huston established an individual style that favored the actors over camera movement and evinced a strong instinct for narrative drama.

William Wyler, known as "Forty-take Willie" for his tendency to shoot scenes over and over until his actors were forced, often through sheer ex-



Coming home after the war isn't too pleasant for (left to right) Homer Parrish (Harold Russell), Fred Derry (Dana Andrews), and Al Stephenson (Fredric March), three veterans trying to adjust to postwar life in William Wyler's *The Best Years of Our Lives* (1946).

haustion, to drop all their mannerisms and deliver a natural, unaffected performance, guided the volcanic Bette Davis through one of her best roles in *Jezebel* (1938), the story of a headstrong young woman in the antebellum

South who insists upon wearing a shocking red dress to a formal ball in defiance of accepted convention. In his other major films of the era, *Wuthering Heights* (1939), the Bette Davis vehicle *The Letter* (1940), and the epic drama of soldiers returning home after World War II, *The Best Years of Our Lives* (1946), Wyler created a delicately nuanced personal universe, in which men and women struggle against their inner natures and society's constraints to fulfill their desires, dreams, and ambitions, often at great cost. Wyler is one of the supreme technicians of the sound era, and his meticulous attention to the mechanics of performance results in some of the most deeply considered and carefully constructed films of the classical cinema.

DOROTHY ARZNER

In an industry that was deeply influenced by a group of women artists from the 1890s onward, only one woman survived the conglomeration of the industry in the late 1920s to direct during the sound era: Dorothy Arzner. Before Arzner, many women had been active as directors in early Hollywood,

but nearly all had been pushed out of the industry with the advent of sound. Arzner's entry into the movie business was like that of many male directors. She attended the University of Southern California with plans to become a doctor but dropped out to pursue a career in motion pictures. Her first job was typing scripts. Later she moved up to an editing position as a cutter for Realart Studio, a subsidiary of Paramount. She edited fifty-two films there as chief editor, including the Rudolph Valentino vehicle *Blood and Sand* (1922).

In addition, Arzner directed some of the grueling second-unit scenes for *Blood and Sand*, depicting the bullfights. She bargained with Paramount for her first opportunity as director, *Fashions for Women* (1927). She then directed a handful of other films before hitting her stride with *The Wild Party* (1929), starring Clara Bow. Of all the films she directed for Paramount, *The Wild Party* displays the most overtly expressed lesbian consciousness. Set at an all-female college, the film is ostensibly a heterosexual romance, but Arzner allows same-sex sexuality to develop between peripheral women characters. *The Wild Party* was also hailed for its technical achievements. It was the first sound picture made at Paramount, in which Arzner reportedly suggested the use of a fishing pole as a microphone extension, thus inventing the industry's first boom mike.

Working Girls (1931) continued Arzner's penchant for the creation of all-women environments set against the backdrop of patriarchal societal convention. Many of the themes of *Working Girls*, which revolved around the difficulties women face in the male-defined work environment and the manner in which women are so often pitted against one another in society, are revisited in her famous later movie *Dance, Girl, Dance* (1940).

Arzner's female characters were often career oriented. *Christopher Strong* (1933), starring Katharine Hepburn as a world-famous aviator fashioned after Amelia Earhart, is a classic female narrative woven around the choice between family and career. In *Craig's Wife* (1936), Rosalind Russell stars as a manipulative woman so driven to become the embodiment of the perfect housewife that she destroys everyone around her, including herself. The film is a scathing attack on societal restrictions of women at a time when women were being moved back into the domestic sphere. Arzner's last film, *First Comes Courage* (1943), starred Merle Oberon as a woman who sacrifices love for the safety and independence of her country. Halfway through shooting the picture, however, Arzner became seriously ill with pneumonia and took time off to recuperate, but rather than wait for her return, the studio had the film completed as quickly as possible (with Charles Vidor directing,



Katharine Hepburn and Colin Clive in Dorothy Arzner's feminist aviation drama, *Christopher Strong* (1933).

was future director Francis Ford Coppola. In 1974, Arzner was finally honored for her work by the Directors Guild of America.

Between 1943 and 1949, no women directed films at any major Hollywood studio. It was not until 1949, when actress Ida Lupino co-produced, scripted, and directed *Not Wanted*, a drama involving teenage pregnancy, that women again became a force behind the camera. Lupino went on to direct a compelling series of dramas and suspense films in the 1950s.

WOMEN'S PICTURES IN THE 1930S AND 1940S

During the thirties and forties, women made up a large proportion of movie audiences. To take advantage, studios developed a genre that came to be known as women's pictures. These movies varied widely, from serious drama to romance to musical to biopic, with one common feature: they all told stories about women for women. A popular theme in the genre was the changing role of women, involving the proprieties of sexuality, women in the workplace, and the choice between love, career, and home. Though sometimes derided by (often male) critics as overly melodramatic, sentimental, and dependent on preposterous turns of plot, the genre was also wildly popular, with movies starring the likes of Bette Davis, Barbara Stan-

though only Arzner received screen credit). Bitterly disappointed with having the film yanked from her, Arzner realized that she was too independent-minded to fit into the Hollywood system. Shortly after leaving Columbia, she became a pioneer in directing television commercials (for Pepsi-Cola), and developed one of the first filmmaking courses in the United States, at the Pasadena Playhouse in California. Later, she taught filmmaking at UCLA, where one of her early students

wyck, Joan Crawford, and Kay Francis. Indeed, many women's pictures were once hailed as masterpieces.

Kay Francis often played a woman who worked in a predominantly male field, such as the title role in *Mary Stevens, M.D.* (1933). Mary experiences sexism firsthand when she is snubbed by female patients because she is a woman. When she sets her sights on a male doctor, a friend tells her that she has no chance with men: because Mary works in a male field, "you have no sex appeal." Like many such films, *Mary Stevens, M.D.* sends a conflicting message. On the one hand, Francis's character is a strong female role model. Confident in her medical skills, Mary saves a baby from choking by using one of her own hairpins. But romance only ruins this strong female doctor. She becomes pregnant out of wedlock and is forced to give birth aboard a ship as she flees to Europe in order to have her baby secretly. Her child dies, and feeling at fault Mary decides to give up her career. It was this type of role that made Kay Francis an enormously popular star, adored by women who tried to emulate her on-screen courage and fashion sensibility.

A popular sub-genre of the women's picture was the maternal melodrama. In these movies, women have children out of wedlock and are forced to give them up so that the children can be reared with privileges the mother cannot offer. When mother and children are somehow reunited years later, the children do not recognize her. Though these women suffer terribly for others, they also offered female audiences a role model of heroic, courageous women, rather than one who needs to be saved. Other maternal melodramas include *Back Street* (1932), *I Found Stella Parish* (1935), and *Madame X* (1937).

Women's pictures often allowed audiences a glimpse at alternate choices that women could make if only society allowed. One such movie was Edmund Goulding's *The Great Lie* (1941), starring Mary Astor and Bette Davis, notable not for its convoluted and melodramatic plot but for showing a woman who is much more concerned with her career than her role as a mother. Astor's character is consumed with the desire to be a great concert pianist and shockingly uninterested in motherhood. Though such movies often seemed to undercut themselves with endings that forced the nontraditional woman to suffer, they also tantalized female audiences with alternate models of women who refused to play by the rules of society.

In the forties, as many women entered the workforce to take the place of men serving in World War II, women's pictures remained highly popular. The movies often featured sociopathic women, women with over-the-top

desires (especially sexual) who presented dangers to both society and themselves. This type of role in women's pictures coincides with the rise of the femme fatale in film noir of the late forties and fifties. A superb example of mid-forties psychotic beauty is Gene Tierney in *Leave Her to Heaven* (1945). Tierney plays a jealous and murderous woman who is so intent on being the only person in her husband's life that she murders his wheelchair-bound brother. She is cruel, utterly beautiful, and without a heart.

All these films allowed female audiences an opportunity to vicariously experience excessive love, romance, and sexuality, to judge such behavior, and to consider society's sexual double standards and women's changing roles in American culture. The genre continued to be popular in the 1950s but survives today in only pale form as "chick flicks," focusing especially on teenage girls and young unmarried women for whom romance is paramount.

WALT DISNEY AND UB IWERKS

Walt Disney, more than any other animator, made the cartoon short an integral part of the motion picture experience. He also pioneered the feature-length animated film with the ambitious *Snow White and the Seven Dwarfs* (1937). Disney was not the sole creative force behind the production of his films, however. He started out teaming with Ubbe ("Ub" for short) Iwerks, who did the animation work on most of Disney's early films, including the *Alice in Cartoonland* series in 1923, a pioneering effort to mix live action and animation. The two then developed the character of Oswald the Lucky Rabbit in 1927 and launched a successful series of shorts until they lost the rights to the character in a corporate battle. Although they were left with neither a star nor financial backing, Iwerks and Disney responded by coming up with Mickey Mouse. The silent *Plane Crazy* (1928) became the first Mickey cartoon, and it was a hit.

But Disney, ever the innovator, wanted to work on a cartoon that used music, sound effects, and dialogue, and with Iwerks he created *Steamboat Willie* (1928), for which Disney himself provided Mickey's high, squeaky voice. The film was a smash success. Disney shrewdly resisted all attempts to buy out the character or his fledgling company, determined to control his own commercial and artistic destiny. Mickey Mouse memorabilia itself became an industry, with Disney supervising the licensing of Mickey's image on everything from wristwatches to coffee mugs. In 1930, however, Iwerks left Disney to pursue his own creative dreams, a move that stunned Disney

and forced him to rely on other animators. Iwerks created two successful cartoon series on his own, Flip the Frog and Willie Whopper, both distributed through MGM, but although Iwerks's cartoons were fresh and funny, they never achieved the popularity of the famous mouse. By the late 1930s, it was obvious to Iwerks that his solo career was not going well and he rejoined Disney, although now only as a salaried employee; when he had left Disney in 1930, he sold out his interest in the company, thereby missing out on a fortune.

Disney continued experimenting in his short cartoons, using classical music in *The Skeleton Dance* (1929), the first of the "Silly Symphony" series, and producing the first cartoon in Technicolor, *Flowers and Trees*, in 1932. By 1933, his use of color and the fluidity of the animation had progressed to an astonishing degree, and his team scored a major hit with the short Technicolor cartoon *Three Little Pigs* (1933), featuring the Depression Era hit song "Who's Afraid of the Big Bad Wolf?" which rapidly became an international sensation.

At the same time, Disney introduced the rest of his most famous cartoon characters, including Donald Duck, Goofy, Pluto, and Minnie Mouse. He also continued experimenting with new processes, such as the multiplane camera, which used several layers of plastic cels on which the animated drawings were inked, to create a greater illusion of depth and perspective. He followed *Snow White* with *Pinocchio* in 1940 and *Bambi* in 1942, and also created what many consider his masterpiece, *Fantasia* (1940), a film that used classical music to illustrate a variety of animated sequences, some abstract, others more narrative-based. The film cost a fortune to produce and failed commercially when first released, but Disney's canny distribution practice of re-releasing his films every eight years or so for a new generation of youngsters assured that it would eventually turn a profit. He employed famed conductor Leopold Stokowski and the Philadelphia Orchestra to record the film's sound track, which included selections by Bach, Beethoven, Schubert, Tchaikovsky, Mussorgsky, and Stravinsky. But purists found the film vulgar and kitschy, and Disney's own comments on the film (seeing one sequence for the first time, Disney reportedly exclaimed, "This will make Beethoven!") did little to help critical reception. But despite these reservations the film was certainly a technical triumph, presented in a CinemaScope-like format a full thirteen years before that process was generally adopted, and employing multiple-channel stereophonic sound.

During the war years, Disney's company cranked out patriotic shorts and training films for the armed forces. But as the war ended, Disney's autocratic

management style began to grate on his employees, who often remained uncredited, and they eventually went on strike for better pay, working conditions, and professional recognition. When the strike was eventually resolved, neither side was entirely satisfied with the result. The family atmosphere was gone, but Disney continued to produce a series of box office hits, moving into live-action features and television in the 1950s, with the daily “The Mickey Mouse Club” and “Disneyland,” a weekly anthology series designed to exploit his vast library of old material and advertise new features from the company. In 1955, Disney opened Disneyland, a vast 160-acre amusement park in Anaheim, California, that rapidly became the most famous theme park on the planet. He kept planning new projects and films until his death in 1966, and he left behind a vast organization that bears his name.

LOONEY TUNES AND BETTY BOOP

Another notable animated cartoon entity during the 1930s and 1940s was Leon Schlesinger’s “Looney Tunes and Merrie Melodies” unit, which started up in the early 1930s as a showcase for Warners’ extensive library of popular songs. Early efforts, such as Tom Palmer’s *I’ve Got to Sing a Torch Song* (1933), used former Disney animators as subcontractors to create musical cartoons with little plot or characterization. This changed when Warner Bros. decided to open their own animation unit and hired the groundbreaking directors Isadore “Friz” Freleng, Chuck Jones, Bob Clampett, Tex Avery, and others to crank out cartoons on a regular basis. Stuffed into a ramshackle building at Warner Bros. dubbed “Termite Terrace,” these animators created an anarchic world featuring Bugs Bunny, Daffy Duck, Elmer Fudd, and the rest of their rowdy characters. More than any other cartoon unit, Looney Tunes was aimed at an adult audience, with enough simple humor to keep children entertained. Emphasizing sight gags, violent slapstick, and breakneck pacing, the cartoons included Avery’s *A Wild Hare* (1940), Jones’s *Elmer’s Pet Rabbit* (1941), and Clampett’s *Wabbit Twouble* (1941). Jones specialized in character-driven cartoons, building up gags through repetition and narrative development, while Clampett favored absurdity and wildly plastic exaggeration as his characters reacted to the zany world around them. Chuck Jones became the most famous of the Looney Tunes directors, and long after his retirement toured the country with 35 mm prints of his classic cartoons, delighting new audiences on a series of lecture tours.

Tex Avery was by far the most extreme animator of the group, employing



Tex Avery, the wildest of the classical Hollywood animators, sends up the western in *Wild and Woolfy* (1945).

sledgehammer violence and brutal pratfalls in a series of raucous cartoons that strained the limits of human credulity. Avery quit Warner Bros. at the height of the company's productivity and joined rival MGM (home of William Hanna and Joseph Barbera's "Tom and Jerry") to create Droopy, the Blitz Wolf, and Screwy Squirrel, among other outlandish characters, in such films as *Red Hot Riding Hood* (1943), a hopped-up fairy tale; *Wild and Woolfy* (1945), a western takeoff starring the Blitz Wolf; and *King-Size Canary* (1947), a variation on the classic cat-and-mouse chase. Avery continued in his idiosyncratic vein into the 1950s, doing exactly what he pleased, much to the dismay of MGM's cartoon producer, Fred Quimby. Avery's cartoons at MGM are now considered the high point of his chaotic career, and have an almost cult-like following among animation buffs.

Warner Bros. and MGM never made feature cartoons during their heyday, preferring to concentrate on short, seven-minute cartoons for theatrical release. This strategy left them out in the cold when the market for shorts collapsed with the decline in movie audiences in the 1960s and the demise of the double bill. The characters, however, live on in merchandising and new feature films produced with digital animation, and the classic Warner Bros. and MGM cartoons are regularly run on television, where they attract new generations of fans with each passing year.

In the late 1920s, Max and Dave Fleischer created Betty Boop, a caricature of a Jazz Age flapper, and enjoyed a wave of national popularity. Based in New York, Max had begun as a cartoonist for the *Daily Eagle* in Brooklyn, while Dave started working with his brother in 1920 to create the “Out of the Inkwell” series, a group of cartoons combining animation with live action, starring Koko the Clown. Their Betty Boop cartoons, such as *Betty Boop in Blunderland* (1934), *Betty Boop Snow White* (1933), and *Betty Boop for President* (1932), were wild, surrealist adventures, accompanied by jazz sound tracks by such luminaries as Louis Armstrong and Cab Calloway. The Fleischers also brought the popular comic strip Popeye to the screen, and in 1939 released their first full-length animated cartoon, *Gulliver’s Travels*, a conscious attempt to imitate Disney’s *Snow White*. The film failed to click at the box office, however, and the brothers moved to Florida to cut costs. There they produced one more feature, as well as a string of hyper-realistic

Mae West sizes up a possible conquest in Lowell Sherman’s *She Done Him Wrong* (1933).



cartoons featuring the comic book hero Superman, but financial strains forced them to close their studio soon after.

This was a period when the whole family went to the movies regularly, and cartoons were thus a family affair rather than entertainments aimed exclusively at children. Labor intensive to produce and requiring months to make, these films by the early 1960s simply did not make a profit anymore, due in part to declining theater audiences. MGM, among other studios, closed down their cartoon division, and unemployed artists eventually found a home for their animated shorts on television.

CENSORSHIP

The 1930s and 1940s witnessed major shifts in American culture, with both the Great Depression and America’s entry into World War II, and Hollywood was quick to adapt to audience needs. The sexually charged Mae West, who sparkled in *Night After Night* (1932), *She Done Him Wrong* (1933), and *I’m No Angel* (1933), found herself stymied by the rigid imposition of the Motion Picture Produc-



Watched by Theresa Harris (left), Barbara Stanwyck (right) plots how to get ahead in Alfred E. Green's *Baby Face* (1933), one of the most sexually explicit pre-Code films.

tion Code on 1 July 1934, as pioneered by Will H. Hays and then administered by Joseph Breen. Although the Code had been around since the late 1920s, it remained largely unenforced until a plethora of suggestive films pushed audiences to protest that their children were being exposed to objectionable material. Prominent offenders included Mae West's early movies; William Dieterle's sexually charged drama *Grand Slam* (1933); *Baby Face* (1933), Alfred E. Green's racy tale of a young woman who sleeps her way to the top; Stephen Roberts's lurid *The Story of Temple Drake* (1933), based on William Faulkner's sensationalist novel *Sanctuary*; and Mitchell Leisen's bizarre musical *Murder at the Vanities* (1934), featuring a production number entitled "Sweet Marijuana." With the imposition of the Code, Hollywood, fearing government intervention if they did not comply, was brought to heel. Among the Code's many proscriptions were the warnings that "methods of crime shall not be explicitly presented," "illegal drug traffic must never be presented," "scenes of passion should not be introduced when not essential to the plot," "excessive and lustful kissing, lustful embracing, suggestive postures and gestures, are not to be shown," "miscegenation (sex relationships between the white and black races) is forbidden," "pointed profanity (this



Shirley Temple, perhaps the most popular of all child stars, in the late 1930s.

Chico, Zeppo, Groucho, and Harpo Marx strike a typically anarchic pose on the set of Leo McCarey's *Duck Soup* (1933).

includes the words God, Lord, Jesus, Christ—unless used reverently—Hell, S.O.B., damn, Gawd), or other profane or vulgar expressions, however used, is forbidden,” and that “ministers of religion . . . should not be used as comic characters or as villains.”

The Code had numerous other demands as well, but the effect on the American cinema was dramatic. Far from being a rating system (as today's G, PG, R, and so on), the 1934 Code covered all motion pictures and thus set definitive limits on what could be shown on the screen for any audience. Mae West was about to begin production of her next film, *It Ain't No Sin*, in 1934; by the time the Code had eviscerated her screenplay (West wrote many of the scenarios, as well as much of the dialogue, for her early films), the title had been changed to *Belle of the Nineties* (1934) and the film was a pale shadow of what it might have been. Similarly, the Jean Harlow sex comedy *Born to Be Kissed* was retitled *100 Percent Pure* to please the Hays/Breen office, and then finally released under the indifferent title of *The Girl from Missouri* (1934). Emblematic of the new regime was the astounding success of child star Shirley Temple, whose films *Little Miss Marker* (1934), *Captain January* (1936), and numerous others cemented her hold on the nation's box office as one of the top stars of the American cinema until 1940, when her popularity dwindled



as she approached her teenage years. Then there was the case of the anarchic Marx Brothers, who brilliantly lampooned society in *Animal Crackers* (1930) and *Horse Feathers* (1932), but when their satire of war and politics in *Duck Soup* (1933) left audiences cold, Paramount let the zany team go. They found a new home at MGM, where producer Irving Thalberg suggested that they counterbalance their patented brand of insanity by adding a love interest to their comedies, thus considerably diluting their impact in such films as *A Night at the Opera* (1935), *At the Circus* (1939), and *Go West* (1940).

GONE WITH THE WIND

The most famous film of the era is undoubtedly 1939's *Gone with the Wind*, based on Margaret Mitchell's page-turning best seller about the South during the Civil War. The production was the brainchild of independent producer David O. Selznick (in Hollywood fashion, the "O" stood for nothing; Selznick had no middle name but decided that the initial "O" added dignity to his screen credit). Selznick knew that only Clark Gable could play the role of Rhett Butler. After tortuous negotiations, Selznick struck a deal to borrow Gable from MGM in return for cash, a significant percentage of the profits, and Selznick's assurance that the finished film would be distributed through MGM.

The epic nature of the film required an enormous number of sets, and Selznick's insistence that the film be shot in Technicolor sent the budget still higher. Selznick also conducted a national talent search for the actress to play Scarlett O'Hara, testing everyone from Miriam Hopkins to Joan Bennett before deciding on Vivien Leigh at the last minute. By then production had already begun with the famous "burning of Atlanta" sequence, which consumed all existing sets on the Selznick lot left over from earlier productions.

At least four directors were involved with the film. George Cukor began to direct, but he was fired after Gable expressed his displeasure at the way Cukor was handling the project. Cukor was openly gay at a time when homosexuality was completely taboo in Hollywood, and the homophobic Gable felt that Cukor was spending too much time directing Vivien Leigh and not paying enough attention to his own character. Victor Fleming took over the reins after Cukor's departure, but when Fleming had a nervous breakdown, Sam Wood stepped in until Fleming was well enough to return. In addition, action director B. Reeves "Breezy" Eason handled many of the

full-scale spectacle sequences, and a battalion of writers were assigned to the project, including (for a few days) novelist F. Scott Fitzgerald, with added daily rewrites by Selznick himself. The entire production was designed by the brilliant William Cameron Menzies, who had designed and directed the celebrated British science fiction film *Things to Come* (1936), based on an original screenplay by H. G. Wells. The strong supporting cast included Olivia de Havilland, Leslie Howard, and Hattie McDaniel.

The massive nature of the production drove everyone to the wall; Selznick was taking pep pills on a daily basis just to keep up with the killing pace of production, and the sheer physical size of the film required an army of extras, assistant directors, production assistants, and the services of at least three directors of cinematography, Ernest Haller, Lee Garmes, and Technicolor's houseman, Ray Rennahan. At a mammoth 222 minutes, the film was split in two sections and became an immediate sensation upon its release. Although Selznick toned down the racism in Mitchell's novel considerably, the film is still full of insulting racial stereotypes, and when the film had its world premiere in Atlanta, the film's African American stars, McDaniel and Butterfly McQueen, were not invited. The film's rose-colored view of slavery and the Reconstruction era uncomfortably recalls *The Birth of a Nation*, and yet the film has a hold on the collective national memory that refuses to fade.

HOLLYWOOD GOES TO WAR

In response to World War II, Hollywood produced a mix of escapist fare, political *agit-prop*, modulated social criticism, and, of course, war films. Tay Garnett's *Bataan* (1943) was a brutal war picture that brought the fight overseas back home to small-town American audiences. Mark Sandrich's *So Proudly We Hail!* (1943) was a patriotic paean to wartime nurses, starring Claudette Colbert. Zoltan Korda directed Humphrey Bogart in the hard-hitting war drama *Sahara* (1943), while Lloyd Bacon's *Action in the North Atlantic* (1943), also starring Bogart, was one of the best seagoing war movies, chronicling the work of the Merchant Marine. Billy Wilder directed *Five Graves to Cairo* (1943), featuring Erich von Stroheim as the famed German general Erwin Rommel, leader of Hitler's Afrika Korps.

Several films were made during this period that would later come back to haunt their creators. Lewis Milestone's *The North Star* (a.k.a. *Armored Attack*, 1943), based on a screenplay by Lillian Hellman, tells the story of the inhab-



Dooley Wilson, Humphrey Bogart, and Ingrid Bergman in Michael Curtiz's *Casablanca* (1942).

itants of a small Russian village fighting against the Nazi onslaught, while Michael Curtiz's *Mission to Moscow* (1943) and Gregory Ratoff's *Song of Russia* (1944) highlight U.S.-Soviet wartime cooperation as one of the keys to victory in Europe. *Mission to Moscow* even portrays Stalin as a wise and benevolent leader.

In another vein, Curtiz directed *Casablanca* (1942), one of the most famous and beloved movies ever made, popular enough to be re-released theatrically half a century later. Humphrey Bogart and Ingrid Bergman star in this superb mix of romance, suspense, and political intrigue set in Nazi-occupied North Africa just prior to the U.S. entry into the war. The remarkable supporting cast included Paul Henreid, Claude Rains, Peter Lorre, Sydney Greenstreet, Conrad Veidt, and Dooley Wilson.

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The films of the 1930s and 1940s in Hollywood thus consolidated an industry and gave rise to one of the most powerful and pervasive systems of image

production and distribution that the world has ever known. The motion picture was still in its relative infancy, barely forty years old as a narrative entertainment medium. The pioneers who had built the industry watched in amazement as the Hollywood cinema became an international benchmark for glamour, star power, spectacle, action, and narrative compression. The motion picture industry was now a full-fledged business, with its own awards (the first Academy Awards ceremony was held in 1929), a stable studio system that was a community unto itself, and a worldwide distribution system that ensured Hollywood's continued international dominance.

The United States thus exported a way of life, a set of values and expectations, and a social order to the rest of the world, with the implicit suggestion that Hollywood's cultural dominance was yet another example of manifest destiny. The studios were designed, like an interlocking jigsaw puzzle, to dominate the industry as a whole. But even as Hollywood's pervasive influence increased, work abroad ensured that national film industries throughout the rest of the world would also have a lasting influence on the shape of the cinema. These are commercial pictures still ruled by a personal vision, expressing the needs, desires, and passions of those whom the Hollywood cinema too often marginalized. It is to these films and filmmakers that we now turn.